

CODY × YELLOWSTONE

Aug 6–11, 2026 · Base: 1822 Bleistein Ave · Grant Village Sat night · Rodeo Monday

Times: **ARR** = pull in · **LV** = wheels rolling · **DEP** rows are drives/flights (second time = arrival). Chips like “→ 45 min” = drive time to reach that stop.

Day 1 · Thu Aug 6 — Travel In

GSP → DEN → COD · **land 10:43 PM** · sleep: Bleistein

TODAY’S KIT

Carry-on: chargers + one USB-C cable · Turo app signed in, **license uploaded** · Grant conf screenshot (20977608) · offline maps, park app, playlists downloaded · headlamp packed

☐ **DEP 4:15 PM Depart GSP — UA1866 to Denver**

ARR 5:55 1 hr 40 flight → Denver

Land DEN 5:55 PM. Offline maps, park app, playlists, podcasts downloaded before boarding. Grant confirmation screenshot in photos: **20977608**.

☐ **ARR 5:55 PM Denver layover — eat a real dinner**

LV 9:05 DINNER · 3 hrs
3 hr 10 layover + dinner · *board 9:05, fly → Cody*

Nothing in Cody is open when you land. This is dinner. Board UA5132 at 9:05.

☐ **ARR 10:43 PM Land Cody — grab the truck (contactless)**

LV 11:05 5 min
~20 min truck pickup + photos · *5 min drive → Bleistein*

GMC Sierra 1500 waiting at the airport — Amber texts the exact spot + key location day-of (plate **11T482K**).
Before driving: full walkaround photos/video + odometer shot in the Turo app, even at 11 PM — night pickups are exactly when you skip this and regret it. Body clock says 12:43 AM.

If energized: Walmart run tonight — cooler, ice, water, sandwich stuff, thermos, snacks.

MAP 1822 Bleistein Ave Cody WY · 44.5215, -109.0687

☐ **AT 11:30 PM Bed. No alarm.**

lights out

Tomorrow starts when it starts. Errands first, mountains after.

Day 2 · Fri Aug 7 — The High Loop: Beartooth → Lamar

~220 mi · ~6 hrs driving · home ~10:15 PM · sleep: Bleistein

TODAY'S KIT

Bear spray (buy first) · cooler + ice + lunch/dinner makings · water jugs · grandpa's binoculars · fleece + beanie (Lamar goes cold at dusk) · rain shell · headlamp · camp chairs ×2 · sunscreen + hats · bug spray · thermos · full tank

☐ ARR 7:30 AM Errands run

LV 8:30

BREAKFAST · HOUSE

1 hr errands + load-up · *then roll out*

One Walmart mission (~25 min, ~\$110–140), then gas. If Thursday-night energy allowed an early run, this is just the gap-fill.

COOLER + DRINKS

Cheap cooler (\$15–25, gets abandoned Tuesday) · 2 bags ice (restock Sat) · water gallons ×3–4 · electrolyte packets / Gatorade · Lamar truck-bed drinks

SANDWICH OPERATION

Bread or tortillas · deli meat + cheese · PB + jam · apples/clementines · trail mix · jerky · chips · granola/protein bars (glovebox stash) · grab-breakfast for Sunday 6:30 AM at Grant (pastries / oats cups)

COFFEE KIT

Thermos (\$10, if the house is bare) · instant coffee you can respect (Via or similar — the Sunday huckleberry latte is the reward)

SAFETY + SUNDRIES

Bear spray ~\$50 (if Walmart's wall looks stale, Sunlight Sports downtown opens at 9) · sunscreen SPF 30+ · SPF chapstick · small bug spray · blister bandages / moleskin + ibuprofen · wet wipes + paper towels · zip-locks (sandwiches + phone at the Firehole swim)

JUDGMENT CALLS

Camp chairs ×2, \$10–15 each (four hours in Lamar says yes, twice) · cheap sandals/water shoes if unpacked · road candy for Chief Joseph at 9:45 PM

Then: **full tank** on the way out of town.

☐ DEP 8:30 AM Depart — Chief Joseph Hwy

ARR 9:25

55 min

55 min drive → Dead Indian Pass

North on WY-120, west on 296. Fresh chip seal this summer — easy on loose gravel.

☐ ARR 9:25 AM Dead Indian Pass Overlook

LV 9:50

20 min stop

25 min at the overlook · *60 min drive → Beartooth Pass*

Walk it, don't just shoot it. Clarks Fork canyon and Sunlight Basin below — the country the Nez Perce ran in 1877. The wall to the northwest is where you're headed.

Beta: Big paved lot right at the summit — park anywhere, walk the low stone-wall rim to the interpretive signs at the far end. Best photo angle is from the little knob just past the signs. 15–20 min is the right dose; the road down the other side is the show's second act.

MAP Dead Indian Pass Overlook · 44.7448, -109.3862

☐ ARR 10:50 AM **Beartooth Pass — 10,947 ft**

LV 11:50 → 60 min · a full hour on foot
a full hour on the tundra · 25 min drive → Rock Creek Vista

LOOK FOR

Mountain goats on the crags · pikas squeaking in talus · peak wildflowers · touchable snowfields

The "another planet" report. Wander off the pullout into the tundra — most people give this four minutes. Can be 45°F and blowing while Cody bakes; the layer lives in the truck. (Cruise past Beartooth Lake without stopping — its shore walk is Monday's show with mom.)

Beta: Two pull-offs flank the actual summit sign — use the bigger one on the west side. Walk north off the pavement onto the tundra (it's open travel up here, stay on rock/gravel where you can). Scan the crags south of the road for goats and listen for pika 'eep's in every talus pile. The West Summit overlook a mile further has the classic switchback-view pullout if you want one more stop.

TRAIL · NO FORMAL TRAIL NEEDED

Park the pullout and wander the open tundra 10–20 min on rock and gravel (stay off the fragile plant mats). Want a marked path instead? The Gardner Lake trailhead 0.5 mi down the east side drops to an alpine lake — but save the legs for Trout Lake this afternoon.

MAP Beartooth Pass · 44.9705, -109.4655

☐ ARR 12:15 PM **Rock Creek Vista — TURNAROUND**

LV 12:30 → 25 min
15 min at the rail · 55 min drive → Cooke City

~15 min here, then the hour back over the pass — Cooke City lunch at 1:25. 2,000-ft look down the glacial canyon. This is the top of the day — no Red Lodge descent. Retrace west.

Beta: Big lot, and the overlook is a 300-yard paved path — easiest jaw-drop of the trip. Look straight down Rock Creek's U-shaped glacial canyon; the road you're NOT taking today snakes down its wall. Restrooms here — use them.

MAP Rock Creek Vista Point · 45.0517, -109.4046

☐ ARR 1:25 PM **Cooke City — lunch · GAS · bathroom**

LV 2:10 LUNCH · → 55 min · Miners Saloon
45 min lunch + gas · 25 min drive → NE Entrance

Sit-down burger, no rush. **Last fuel before home.** The full pre-Lamar checklist, handled by a frontier town of ~100.

Beta: Everything is on the one main street: Miners Saloon mid-town on the north side (order at the bar, cash preferred historically), gas at the stations on either end of town — hit whichever's open, they keep frontier hours. Fill the water bottles too; next reliable everything is home.

MAP Miners Saloon Cooke City MT · 45.0864, -109.9330

☐ ARR 2:35 PM **Northeast Entrance**

LV 2:40 → 25 min
5 min at the gate · 20 min drive → Trout Lake

\$35 pass (7 days, keep the receipt) if not already bought. Quietest gate in the park.

☐ ARR 3:00PM **Trout Lake**

LV 4:15 → 20 min · ¾ mi steep · 30 min at the water
1 hr 15 hike + lakeside sit · 15 min drive → Lamar

LOOK FOR

Big cutthroat cruising the shallows · otters (reliable spot) · spray on hip

Her-call flex — short but steep; skipping it costs nothing. Steep climb through Douglas fir to absurdly clear water. First real payoff of the Hokas. Sit and watch the fish patrol.

Beta: Trailhead is a small unsigned-feeling pullout on the north side of the road — if you hit Pebble Creek you went ~1.5 mi too far. The climb is steep but short (15 min of work). At the top, go LEFT around the lake — the inlet creek on the far side is where cutthroat stack and otters hunt. The downed logs along the west shore are the sitting spots.

TRAIL · TROUT LAKE TRAIL · 1.2–1.5 MI RT · ~380 FT · 45–75 MIN

Switchback up through the firs ~15–20 min to the lake. At the top take the shoreline path LEFT (clockwise): ~0.6 mi around, hitting the inlet creek on the far side (stacked cutthroat, otter territory) and the west-shore logs before closing the loop at the outlet. Same steep trail back down.

MAP Trout Lake Trailhead Yellowstone · 44.8996, -110.1223

☐ ARR 4:30PM **LAMAR VALLEY — the evening shift**

LV 8:15 DINNER · COOLER · → 15 min · until sunset 8:15
3 hr 45 in the valley · then the dark drive home

LOOK FOR

Bison herds backlit after 6:30 · pronghorn on the flats · wolves at dusk (the lottery) · grizzly at treeline · scan with grandpa's binoculars

Cruise the valley floor slow, then park where the spotting scopes cluster (pullouts between Slough Creek and Lamar Canyon). Walk up, say "anything moving?" — they'll share the scope.

Cooler dinner from the truck bed. Nearly four hours of just being here. The most in-the-experience block of the trip.

Beta: The prime stretch is the ~6 miles between Lamar Canyon and Slough Creek — big gravel pullouts on both sides. Park FULLY off pavement, engine off, voices low. Glass the river corridor and the treeline seams, not the open middle — that's where things move at dusk. Vault toilets at the Slough Creek road junction and Lamar Canyon. If scopes cluster somewhere, that's not a suggestion, it's intel: join them.

MAP Lamar Valley (prime pullout stretch) · 44.8977, -110.2245

☐ DEP 8:15PM **Depart — Chief Joseph in the dark**

ARR 10:15 ~2 hrs · deer-speed
2 hr drive → Cody, deer-speed

Elk own this road at night. Home ~10:15. Tomorrow departs at 6 or 7 — both pre-approved. Pack the small overnight bag before bed.

Day 3 · Sat Aug 8 — Canyon + Storm Point → Grant

~140 mi one-way · ~4 hr driving · out the door 8:30 · together all day · sleep: **Grant Village**

TODAY'S KIT

Overnight bags ×2 · swimsuits + towels + sandals (plunge tonight, Firehole tomorrow) · daypack: water ×4, rim picnic lunch, shells, fleeces, beanies, sunscreen, bear spray, headlamp, charger, binos · cooler restocked + fresh ice · buy tomorrow's coffee + grab-breakfast tonight

☐ DEP 8:30 AM **Depart — overnight bags packed**

ARR 9:35 BREAKFAST · QUICK · sleep-in default
65 min drive → East Entrance

8:30 is the plan now — no summit to fund, so the morning is civilized. Big duffels stay at the house.

☐ ARR 9:35 AM **East Entrance + Lake Butte Overlook**

LV 10:10 → 65 min · her first full-lake view
gate + overlook · 50 min drive → Mud Volcano

LOOK FOR

Grizzly on the Sylvan corridor — one of the park's best roadside bear stretches

Show the pass, then swing the Lake Butte spur — now a standard stop: the whole lake below, and on clear mornings the Tetons on the far southern horizon.

MAP Lake Butte Overlook · 44.4933, -110.2668

☐ ARR 11:00 AM **Mud Volcano + Dragon's Mouth**

LV 11:40 → 50 min · full loop ~40 min
40 min boardwalk loop · 20 min drive → Canyon

LOOK FOR

Dragon's Mouth growling (steam collapsing in the cave) · bison lounging on warm ground

Clockwise: stairs up to Churning Caldron + Sour Lake, down past Black Dragon's Caldron, Dragon's Mouth by the lot last. Bison get 25 yards, always.

MAP Mud Volcano · 44.6249, -110.4382

☐ ARR 12:00 PM **GRAND CANYON — together, at your pace**

LV 2:30 LUNCH · RIM PICNIC · → 20 min · ~2.5 hrs
2 hr 30 on the rims + picnic · 20 min drive → Hayden

LOOK FOR

Ospreys nesting on canyon spires · midday rainbow in the falls mist

South rim first: Artist Point (200-yd paved — the postcard), then the Point Sublime rim trail east from the deck — level, out-and-back as far as she's enjoying it. Picnic on the rim.

North rim (10-min drive, one-way): Lookout Point + Inspiration Point. **The choice, made at the rail:** the Brink of the Lower Falls drop — 0.7 mi RT, ~600 ft of switchbacks, standing ON the falls, do it together if she's game — or Red Rock Point below Lookout instead: 0.4 mi RT, half the drop, the falls still filling your ears. Either is the full experience.

TRAIL · THE RIMS, SHARED PACE · 2–3 MI TOTAL · ~2.5 HR

Artist Point + Sublime (level, turn around anytime) · THEN one of: Brink 0.7 mi RT / 600 ft · or Red Rock 0.4 mi RT / ~500 ft gentler · Inspiration Point 5–10 min.

MAP Artist Point · 44.7201, -110.4794

☐ ARR 2:50 PM **Hayden Valley — rolling pass, southbound**

LV 3:15 → 20 min · windows down
25 min rolling · 25 min drive → Storm Point

LOOK FOR

Bison jams (pay the toll happily) · elk + grizzly on far treelines · the Grizzly Overlook pullout, west side ~4 mi south of Canyon

Golden hour comes back through here in memory — today it's the mid-afternoon cruise. Second pass at bison country happens tomorrow.

☐ ARR 3:40 PM **STORM POINT — the shared hike**

LV 5:10 → 25 min · 2.3 mi flat · ~1.5 hr
1 hr 30 loop + beach sit · 25 min drive → Lake Hotel

LOOK FOR

The marmot colony in the point's boulders · waterfowl on Indian Pond · whitecaps on the biggest alpine lake in North America

Washburn's honorable replacement, and the right one: flat, gorgeous, together the whole way.

TRAIL · STORM POINT LOOP · 2.3 MI · FLAT · ~1.5 HR

Trailhead pullout at Indian Pond, 3 mi east of Fishing Bridge. Loop clockwise: past the pond, through lodgepole forest, out to the windswept point — marmots in the rocks — then the beach stretch below before closing the loop. Take the breather on the sand.

MAP Storm Point Trailhead · 44.5599, -110.3283

☐ ARR 5:35 PM **Lake Yellowstone Hotel — porch dinner**

LV 6:50 DINNER · → 25 min · unhurried
1 hr 15 dinner · 35 min drive → Grant

1891 colonnade, sunroom bar seats walk-ins with the same lake view, porch rockers free. Dinner, not a stop.

MAP Lake Yellowstone Hotel · 44.5514, -110.4003

☐ ARR 7:25 PM **Grant Village — CHECK IN**

SWIM #1 · OPTIONAL · → 35 min · conf 20977608

evening is yours — plunge + stars · sleep here

Registration building as you enter the village — room is set for two. Ask the desk: **“Is the Firehole swim area open this year?”** + the easiest lakeshore walk.

Swim #1 (optional): the 30-second plunge off the beach by the amphitheater — waist deep, dunk, out, towels, shared bragging rights.

~10:00 PM: the lakeshore, facing south, ten dark minutes. The Milky Way core over the water — with company this time. Solve tomorrow’s coffee tonight; sell the 6:40 alarm with the empty-boardwalk pitch. Bed.

MAP Grant Village Lodge · 44.3931, -110.5581

Day 4 · Sun Aug 9 — Geyser Dawn Sweep → Home → Mustangs

~215 mi · ~4 hr 15 driving in six short hops · the crown-jewel day · sleep: Bleistein

TODAY'S KIT

Thermos coffee + packed breakfast · swimsuits + towels ×2 + sandals (Firehole) · water ×3 · sunscreen + SPF chapstick · bear spray (Fairy Falls walk) · binoculars for the mustangs · cooler lunch

☐ DEP 6:40 AM Depart Grant

ARR 6:45 BREAKFAST · PACKED · coffee from thermos
5 min drive → West Thumb

Checkout is a key-drop. Five minutes to the reason for everything.

☐ ARR 6:45 AM WEST THUMB — dawn steam

LV 7:25 → 5 min · ~1 hr
40 min empty boardwalk · 35 min drive → Old Faithful

LOOK FOR

Black Pool's impossible blue · Abyss Pool · Fishing Cone in the lake · elk browsing basin margins

The moment the room bought. Fork RIGHT from the parking path (friend's beta) down to the lakeside walk first. Steam columns off springs draining into the cold lake, low sun across the water, boardwalk empty, ground gurgling.

Beta: One lot at the end of the short spur; boardwalk is a figure-8 — your fork-right move puts you on the lakeside leg first: Fishing Cone sits just offshore, then Black Pool and Abyss Pool (the two impossible blues) anchor the far corner. Full walk is ~0.6 mi. Elk often graze the basin edge at this hour — give them the boardwalk if they're on it.

TRAIL · WEST THUMB BOARDWALK · 0.6 MI FIGURE-8 · FLAT · 40–60 MIN

Fork RIGHT onto the lakeside leg first (Fishing Cone, Black Pool, Abyss Pool), then take the inner loop on the way back to the lot.

MAP West Thumb Geyser Basin · 44.4166, -110.5732

☐ ARR 8:00 AM Old Faithful + Upper Geyser Basin

LV 9:35 HUCKLEBERRY LATTE · → 35 min · ~1.5 hrs
1 hr 35 basin + Inn + latte · 15 min drive → Fairy Falls lot

LOOK FOR

Beehive Geyser if its indicator's going (better show) · Firehole River steaming

Over Craig Pass — the Continental Divide, twice. Check the eruption board on arrival, walk **Geyser Hill** while waiting. Then the Inn's 1904 log lobby — 76 feet of lodgepole gothic — and the **huckleberry latte** at the espresso cart. Buses land ~9:30 as you leave.

Beta: Park in the enormous main lot, then check the prediction board in the visitor center window first — it sets your sequence. Geyser Hill is the 1.3-mi boardwalk loop ACROSS the footbridge behind Old Faithful — if Beehive's indicator cone is spouting, drop everything and wait (10–15 min warning, taller than Old Faithful, no crowd). The Inn is free to wander: lobby, mezzanine, and the espresso cart is on the lobby's left side.

MAP Old Faithful Visitor Education Center · 44.4586, -110.8281

☐ ARR 9:50 AM **GRAND PRISMATIC — Fairy Falls Overlook**

LV 10:30 → 15 min · 0.6 mi walk · ~45 min
40 min walk + overlook · 15 min drive → *Firehole Canyon*

The single most otherworldly color you will ever see outdoors: 370 ft of boiling turquoise ringed in orange — thermophile bacteria mats, each ring a temperature band. Sun's high enough to fire it; the mob is 45 minutes behind you.

Beta: Use the Fairy Falls TRAILHEAD lot, 1 mi south of the Midway lot everyone fights over. Cross the steel bridge, follow the wide gravel road 0.6 mi, then the signed overlook spur climbs left ~100 ft to the platform. Same way back. Total ~1.5 mi — sandals fine, but the boardwalk-brain move is real shoes.

TRAIL · GRAND PRISMATIC OVERLOOK · 1.6 MI RT · ~105 FT · 40–50 MIN

Cross the steel bridge, follow the wide old roadbed 0.6 mi, then the signed overlook spur climbs LEFT ~0.2 mi to the platform. Running ahead of schedule? The main trail continues 0.8 mi to Fairy Falls itself — a 197-ft ribbon — adding ~1.6 mi RT / 45 min.

MAP Fairy Falls Trailhead · 44.5155, -110.8325

☐ ARR 10:45 AM **Firehole Canyon — Swim #2 (if open)**

LV 11:20 SWIM #2 · VERIFY FIRST → 15 min · 45 min
35 min swim window · 40 min drive → *Norris*

Thermally-warmed river (high 70s–80s°) in a lava canyon — the one warm swim in the park. **It was closed ALL of 2025** for high water, and 2026 status was unconfirmed at press time, so verify before counting on it:

1. Park app / nps.gov Alerts while you still have signal Saturday · **2.** Ask the ranger at the East gate or the Grant desk at check-in — they'll know instantly · **3.** The lot itself: towels on rocks = yes, barricade = scenic drive.

Drive the 2-mi Firehole Canyon spur regardless — canyon walls + Firehole Falls make it worth it even dry. If swimming: real current, no lifeguard, stay in the main pool with everyone else, sandals on (volcanic rock bottom).

MAP Firehole Swimming Area · 44.6293, -110.8630

☐ ARR 12:00 PM **NORRIS GEYSER BASIN — both loops**

LV 1:50 → 40 min · ~2 hrs
1 hr 50 both loops · 25 min drive → *Canyon fuel stop*

LOOK FOR

Steamboat's runoff channel (world's tallest geyser) · the hiss of Porcelain Basin

The finale — hottest, oldest, most volatile ground in the park. **Porcelain Basin first:** the alien one, a treeless bowl of vents and milky-blue runoff. Then Back Basin past Steamboat. Artists Paintpots (1-mi loop) optional en route if ahead of schedule.

Beta: Both loops leave from the little museum at the lot: Porcelain Basin (0.8 mi) drops north into the alien bowl — do it first — then Back Basin (1.5 mi) loops south past Steamboat (check its runoff channel: wet and steaming means it's been active) and Echinus. Noon lot takes patience; a spot always opens. Bookstore at the museum for the one souvenir that's not junk.

TRAIL · NORRIS LOOPS · 2.3 MI TOTAL · ~1.5–2 HR

Porcelain Basin loop first: 0.8 mi dropping north from the museum into the bowl, 30–40 min. Then the Back Basin loop: 1.5 mi — walk it counterclockwise so Steamboat and Emerald Spring come early, 45–60 min.

MAP Norris Geyser Basin · 44.7264, -110.7031

☐ DEP **2:15 PM** **Homebound — Canyon fuel → Hayden → East gate**

ARR 4:50 LUNCH · CANYON · ~2 hrs 10 total

2 hr 35 drive → Cody, fuel + Hayden pass en route

Snack + gas at Canyon Village, one last Hayden pass (bison don't check the clock), out over Sylvan. Cody ~4:50.

Beta: Canyon Village has gas AND the general store — this is the Wilcoxson's huckleberry ice cream stop (92-year park tradition, huckleberry is the correct flavor). Ten minutes, then wheels south.

MAP Canyon Village General Store · 44.7351, -110.4885

☐ ARR **6:00 PM** **McCullough Peaks mustangs — golden hour**

LV 8:35 → 25 min · dirt roads · skip if rain

2 hr 35 golden hour with the horses · 25 min drive → downtown

LOOK FOR

Wild horse bands · stallion posturing · foals · banded clay lighting up at dusk

East on 14/16/20 to the BLM two-tracks. The trip's last new landscape — desert badlands, nobody there.

Beta: Take US 14/16/20 east ~13 miles, then the signed BLM two-track entrances on the north side (Whistle Creek area). Any dry two-track works — drive until badlands surround you, then stop and glass the ridgelines and low draws; the bands move toward water at dusk. Stay 100+ ft from horses (they'll let you closer; don't). High-clearance happy, but turn around at anything rutted — no cell service out here.

MAP McCullough Peaks HMA (two-track entry) · 44.5583, -108.7379

☐ ARR **9:00 PM** **Walk downtown — Silver Dollar or Chamberlin**

DINNER · DOWNTOWN

nightcap · walk home

Live music with the wranglers, or the quiet bar where Hemingway signed the register in '32. You've earned either.

Day 5 · Mon Aug 10 — Sunlight Gorge + Beauty Lake + Rodeo

Option A: ~155 mi · ~3 hr 30 driving · the headliner day · sleep: Bleistein

TODAY'S KIT

Swimsuits worn under clothes · towels x2 · water shoes · dry changes · picnic lunch + water x4 · warm layers for BOTH (9,000 ft runs 20° cooler) · walking shoes · sunscreen + hats · binoculars · tonight: bags zipped, bear spray + leftover food staged with a note

THE FORK — DECIDE OVER COFFEE

Option A (default, below): Sunlight Gorge → Beauty Lake walk + Swim #3 + picnic → optional Sunlight Basin dip → Irma → rodeo. **Option B (the Beartooth full send):** if Friday's high country stole both your hearts — over the top to Red Lodge: rolling Dead Indian ~10:25 · Beartooth Lake 11:10 · the Pass again 11:40 · Rock Creek Vista 12:20 · Red Lodge main-street lunch + Coffee Factory Roasters 1:00–2:15 · back over the top · home ~4:50 · same Irma + rodeo evening. **The price of B:** it costs the Beauty Lake swim — the planned crown of the trip. A is the plan; B exists so the choice is yours, not the schedule's.

☐ DEP 9:30 AM Roll out — Chief Joseph, fourth and finest

ARR 10:45 BREAKFAST · SLOW · latest start of the trip
70 min drive → Sunlight Gorge Bridge (Dead Indian = rolling 5-min leg-stretch — you've both stood there)

Slow coffee, suits under clothes, picnic in the cooler. Day-5 legs get the trip's gentlest morning.

☐ ARR 10:45 AM Sunlight Gorge Bridge

LV 10:55 → 70 min · 2-min gasp
10 min on the walkway · 40 min drive → Beartooth Lake trailhead

Highest bridge in Wyoming. Park the pull-off just past it, walk back out on the walkway, look straight down 300 feet into the slot. New for you both — Friday skips it on purpose.

MAP Sunlight Creek Bridge · 44.7511, -109.5588

☐ ARR 11:35 AM BEAUTY LAKE — walk, Swim #3, picnic

LV 2:30 PM SWIM #3 · THE HEADLINER · LUNCH · LAKESIDE PICNIC · → 40 min · turn around anytime
~3 hr walk + swim + picnic · then the flex, or home

LOOK FOR

Peak August wildflowers · Beartooth Butte's striped face over the water · marmots on the granite · trout rising in Beauty Lake

Gentle rolling trail at 9,000 ft — gorgeous within ten minutes. **She sets the pace and the turnaround.**

THE SWIM: Beauty Lake is the swimmable one up here — shallowest = warmest, top few feet brisk-but-doable by early afternoon, and today's window has a full extra hour of slack. Sandy/granite shelf entries where the trail first meets the lake. Suits already on; she wades the shelf while you swim; stay near shore. Out — towels — dry layers immediately — the breeze flips wet-and-happy fast.

Then the granite picnic, feet drying in the sun, trout rising. The trip's highlight reel, shared.

TRAIL · BEAUTY LAKE · ~2.8 MI RT · ~300 FT · ~1.5 HR WALKING AT MOM PACE

Park at the Beartooth Lake boat launch. East shore north ~½ mi · rock-hop the inlet creek (water shoes shine) · wildflower meadows · stay RIGHT at the ~1-mi junction · lake at ~1.4 mi, sandy entries at first shoreline. Turning around early anywhere = a complete hike.

MAP Beartooth Lake Trailhead · 44.9440, -109.5891

☐ ARR 3:15 PM **FLEX — Sunlight Basin Road dip**

LV 3:45 optional · gravel, turn around anytime
~30 min in the basin · ~90 min drive home

Only if you're rolling ahead and want one more: the gravel road at the bridge junction drops ~7 mi into the actual basin floor — old dude-ranch valley under big walls. Twenty minutes in, turn around whenever. You saw it from above; this is being inside it. Skip freely — the overlook already gave you the postcard.

MAP Sunlight Basin Road turnoff · 44.7495, -109.5638

☐ ARR 5:15 PM **The house — shower, regroup**

LV 6:20 actual downtime
1 hr to be humans · *walk to the Irma*

The trip's only built-in nothing. Use it.

☐ ARR 6:45 PM **Irma Hotel — dinner**

LV 7:40 DINNER · walkable
55 min dinner · 5 min drive → rodeo grounds

Buffalo Bill's own hotel, prime rib, the cherrywood bar. She swam an alpine lake today — that's a dinner story.

MAP Irma Hotel · 44.5262, -109.0632

☐ ARR 7:45 PM **Cody Nite Rodeo**

LV 10:00 8:00 start · Buzzard's Roost side
2 hr 15 of rodeo · *then home to pack*

West grandstand, evening sun behind you, seat her back from the rail if dust bothers her. The last night: tundra, wolves, canyon, geysers, mustangs, an alpine-lake swim — and a rodeo.

MAP Cody Nite Rodeo · 44.5219, -109.1042

☐ AT 10:00 PM **Pack — truck goes back in the morning**

bags zipped · lights out

Bear spray stays at the house with a note — it cannot fly, even checked. Leftover cooler food too. Drop-off deadline 9:30 AM.

Day 6 · Tue Aug 11 — Travel Home

COD → DEN → EWR → GSP · land 11:03 PM

TODAY'S KIT

Boarding passes · every charger out of the walls · full tank before drop-off · Turo exit photos + fuel-gauge shot · Denver food money · patience for the EWR sprint

☐ ARR 8:15 AM **Fill the tank → drop the truck at COD**

LV 9:40 full tank required · drop by 9:30 · exit photos
1 hr 25 gas + drop-off + exit photos · *walk into the terminal*

Gas on Big Horn Ave ~8:15 (Turo requires full at return), then the truck goes back to **2101 Roger Sedam Drive** — keys per Amber's instructions, **final walkaround photos + fuel-gauge shot in the app**. An hour before the flight is genuinely plenty at COD.

MAP 2101 Roger Sedam Drive Cody WY · 44.5170, -109.0290

☐ DEP 10:10 AM **UA5079 → Denver 11:55**

ARR 11:55 LUNCH · DENVER
fly → Denver, land 11:55

Buy real food in Denver — the day is long.

☐ DEP 1:42 PM **UA1505 → Newark 7:35**

ARR 7:35 ⚠ 72-min connection
fly → Newark · ⚠ 72-min connection

Check arrival + departure gates before landing. Walk with purpose. If it goes sideways, United's next-morning GSP options are thin — patience is packed.

☐ DEP 9:27 PM **UA3681 → GSP 11:03 PM**

ARR 11:03 *fly → GSP · home 11:03 PM*

Home. Seven kinds of awe in the bag.

Reference

Bookings, orders, and the daypack

GRANT VILLAGE — SAT AUG 8

Confirmation	20977608
Room	Deluxe Lodge · 1 Queen (ADA roll-in shower)
Check-in / out	after 4:00 PM / by 11:00 AM
Rate	\$321 + tax (~\$370)
Address	24 Rainbow Loop, YNP
Lodges line	307-344-7311

SACRIFICE ORDER — PRE-SIGNED, ZERO GUILT

- Trout Lake · Paintpots · Firehole swim · Sunlight Basin road — drop freely
- Lake Butte spur · late starts are pre-approved everywhere
- Storm Point — a canyon + porch-dinner Saturday still lands
- **Nothing else.** Lamar, Grant, the dawn sweep, and mom day are the trip.

STANDING ORDERS

- Tank above half · gas at Cooke City (Fri), Canyon (Sun), Cody (always)
- Bear spray on hip beyond boardwalks · stays in Cody with a note on the 10th
- No cotton on mountain days · layers for 40° dawns → 90° afternoons
- Text mom the day's shape each morning before losing signal
- Storms build after 2 PM — summit early, descend when clouds stack
- Dark drives at deer-speed: Chief Joseph (Fri), Wapiti (any late return)
- Odometer photo at pickup · cap 1,000 mi · plan ~735 (~265-mi cushion)
- Thermopolis = rain card (~170 mi RT — still fits the cushion)

DAYPACK LOADOUT

- Water ×2 · lunch · rain shell · fleece · beanie
- Headlamp (fresh batteries) · bear spray · portable charger
- Grandpa's binoculars · swimsuit + small towel (Sunday)

NUMBERS & BACKUPS

- Xanterra lodges (Grant changes): 307-344-7311
- Turo host Amber texts pickup spot + keys day-of · truck lives at 2101 Roger Sedam Dr (COD)
- Turo #59595627 · GMC Sierra 1500 · plate 11T482K · **upload driver's license Wednesday** (app prompts 24 h before)
- Return full tank · no smoking, no pets in cab · \$.61/mi past 1,000
- Park emergencies: 911 from developed areas · signal islands at Canyon, Lake, Grant, Old Faithful

